

Lecture Points

Politics of New Provinces in Pakistan

1. Introduction: The Debate Over New Provinces

Pakistan currently consists of **four provinces**:

- Punjab
- Sindh
- Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KPK)
- Balochistan

Along with these provinces, there are also **federal territories**, including:

- Islamabad Capital Territory
- Gilgit-Baltistan
- Azad Jammu and Kashmir (AJK)

The issue of creating new provinces has been debated in Pakistan for many decades. It is one of the most significant discussions related to federalism, governance, and political representation.

Why Do Regions Demand New Provinces?

Many regions in Pakistan feel politically and economically marginalized within their existing provinces. These grievances often lead to demands for separate provinces.

Major Reasons Behind the Demands

1. Unequal Development

Large provinces often concentrate development in major cities, leaving peripheral areas underdeveloped.

Example:

- Lahore receives a large share of Punjab's development funds.
- South Punjab regions like Rajanpur or Dera Ghazi Khan lag behind in infrastructure.

2. Administrative Inefficiency

Very large provinces are difficult to manage effectively.

Example:

Punjab has a population of over 120 million people, making it one of the largest administrative units in the world.

Many experts argue that smaller administrative units could improve governance.

3. Cultural and Linguistic Identity

Some regions believe their language, culture, and identity are ignored.

Example:

- Seraiki speakers believe their language is not properly recognized.
- Hazara people argue their Hindko culture differs from Pashtun identity.

4. Political Representation

Smaller regions often feel they lack representation in provincial governments.

Example:

Most chief ministers of Punjab historically came from Central Punjab, not South Punjab.

2. Constitutional Framework for Creating New Provinces

The Constitution of Pakistan provides a legal mechanism for creating new provinces.

Article 239(4)

This article states:

A constitutional amendment that alters the limits of a province must be approved by the Provincial Assembly of that province with a two-thirds majority.

Steps Required to Create a New Province

1. A constitutional amendment bill must be introduced in Parliament.
2. It must receive a two-thirds majority in both houses:
 - National Assembly
 - Senate
3. The provincial assembly concerned must also approve it with a two-thirds majority.

Why Is It Difficult?

Because:

- Political parties often disagree.
- Provincial elites resist losing territory and resources.
- Ethnic sensitivities make consensus difficult.

Example

If South Punjab becomes a province:

- Punjab Assembly must approve the division of Punjab.

But political leaders from Central Punjab may oppose losing power.

3. Historical Background of Provincial Reorganization

Understanding the politics of new provinces requires examining Pakistan's historical experience.

A. One Unit Scheme (1955–1970)

In 1955, the government merged all provinces of West Pakistan into one administrative unit called "West Pakistan."

Purpose:

- To create administrative parity with East Pakistan (Bangladesh).
- To reduce provincial divisions.

Problems with the One Unit Scheme

The policy created resentment among smaller ethnic groups.

Groups such as:

- Sindhis
- Baloch
- Pashtuns

felt that the scheme allowed Punjab to dominate politics and administration.

Abolition of One Unit

In 1970, the One Unit system was abolished and the original provinces were restored.

This showed that centralized systems ignoring regional identities cannot survive long.

4. Major Demands for New Provinces in Pakistan

Several regions have demanded new provinces based on administrative, linguistic, or political reasons.

A. South Punjab Province

The demand for South Punjab province is one of the strongest provincial movements in Pakistan.

Regions Included

- Multan
- Bahawalpur
- Dera Ghazi Khan

- Rahim Yar Khan
- Bahawalnagar

Reasons for Demand

1. Development Gap

South Punjab is less developed compared to northern and central Punjab.

Indicators show:

- Higher poverty rates
- Lower literacy levels
- Fewer hospitals and universities

2. Political Marginalization

South Punjab leaders claim:

- Provincial leadership is dominated by Central Punjab.
- Budget allocations favor cities like Lahore, Faisalabad, and Rawalpindi.

3. Administrative Distance

People from remote districts must travel long distances to reach provincial offices in Lahore.

Political Promises

Many political parties promise South Punjab province during elections.

Examples:

- PTI promised a South Punjab secretariat in 2018.
- PPP also historically supported the idea.

However, no government has yet completed the constitutional process.

B. Bahawalpur Province (Restoration)

Bahawalpur was previously a princely state.

Before 1955:

- It had its own ruler (Nawab of Bahawalpur).
- It maintained administrative autonomy.

Why Do People Demand Restoration?

Supporters argue:

- Bahawalpur had a strong administrative system.
- Its resources were later absorbed into Punjab.

They believe restoration would help preserve regional identity and improve governance.

C. Hazara Province

The Hazara region includes:

- Abbottabad
- Mansehra
- Haripur
- Battagram

Trigger for the Movement

In 2010, the North-West Frontier Province was renamed Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

Hazara residents protested because:

- The new name emphasized Pashtun identity.
- Hazara people speak Hindko, not Pashto.

Outcome

Large protests erupted, and some protesters were killed during clashes with police.

Since then, the demand for Hazara Province has remained politically active.

D. Seraiki Province

The Seraiki movement is based primarily on linguistic identity.

Seraiki Language

Seraiki is spoken in southern districts of Punjab.

Supporters argue:

- Pakistan already has provinces based on language:
 - Sindh (Sindhi)
 - KPK (Pashto)

Therefore, they believe Seraiki speakers deserve their own province.

Political Support

Some regional parties and activists actively campaign for a Seraiki province.

E. Urban Sindh (Muhajir Province)

Some political groups have proposed creating a province for Karachi and Hyderabad.

Supporters claim:

- Urban Sindh contributes most of the tax revenue.
- Yet development decisions are controlled by rural Sindh political elites.

Opposition

Sindhi nationalist parties strongly oppose the idea because they fear it would:

- weaken Sindh's political power
- divide the province along ethnic lines.

F. FATA Reforms

Before 2018, the Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) had a separate legal system under Frontier Crimes Regulation (FCR).

Reform Process

In 2018, the government merged FATA into Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

This reform:

- abolished FCR
- extended Pakistani legal and administrative systems to the region.

Significance

The FATA merger shows that territorial reorganization is possible when political consensus exists.

5. Arguments in Favor of New Provinces

Supporters present several arguments.

1. Better Governance

Smaller provinces are easier to manage.

Example:

India created new states such as Uttarakhand, Jharkhand, and Telangana to improve administration.

2. Balanced Development

New provinces may ensure more equitable distribution of resources.

Example:

If South Punjab becomes a province, its government may prioritize local development.

3. Political Empowerment

Local populations would gain greater political representation.

4. Strengthening Federalism

A stronger federal structure can emerge when regions feel satisfied with their autonomy.

6. Arguments Against New Provinces

Opponents also present strong concerns.

1. Ethnic Fragmentation

Creating provinces based on ethnicity could increase divisions.

Pakistan already faces ethnic tensions in some regions.

2. Financial Costs

Establishing new provinces requires:

- new government buildings
- new bureaucracies
- new judicial institutions.

This requires significant financial resources.

3. Political Manipulation

Some politicians use the issue to gain votes but never implement reforms.

4. Administrative Complexity

Too many provinces could complicate coordination between federal and provincial governments.

7. Positions of Political Parties

Political parties often change their stance depending on electoral interests.

Examples:

- **PTI** supports South Punjab province.
- **PPP** historically supports administrative division of Punjab.
- **PML-N** has been cautious because its political base is in Punjab.

Regional parties strongly support provinces representing their ethnic groups.

8. Administrative vs Ethnic Provinces

Two major models exist.

Administrative Model

Provinces created for administrative efficiency.

Example:

Divide Punjab into **North, Central, and South Punjab**.

Advantages:

- reduces ethnic tensions
- improves governance.

Ethnic Model

Provinces created based on cultural identity.

Example:

Seraiki province.

Advantages:

- recognizes cultural rights
- strengthens identity.

Disadvantage:

- may intensify ethnic politics.

9. Impact of the 18th Amendment

The **18th Constitutional Amendment (2010)** significantly strengthened provincial autonomy.

Key features:

- more financial resources to provinces
- abolition of Concurrent Legislative List
- increased authority over education, health, and culture.

Effect on New Province Demands

Because provinces now hold more power, smaller regions feel even stronger motivation to demand their own provincial governments.

10. Federalism and Stability

Federalism balances power between:

- central government
- provincial governments.

If some regions feel ignored, it weakens national unity.

Creating new provinces may improve representation and strengthen the federation if managed carefully.

11. Major Challenges

Several challenges prevent the creation of new provinces.

1. Constitutional requirements
2. Political disagreements
3. Ethnic sensitivities
4. Economic constraints
5. Fear of precedent (other regions may demand provinces).

12. Economic Implications

New provinces require major administrative investments.

These include:

- provincial secretariats
- police forces
- courts
- development agencies.

However, supporters argue improved governance may lead to better economic growth in the long run.

13. International Examples

Many countries have reorganized administrative units.

Examples:

India

- Created Telangana in 2014.
- Several new states were created after independence.

Nigeria

- Increased from 3 regions to 36 states.

These examples show that territorial reorganization is common in federal systems.

14. Political Reality in Pakistan

Despite strong debates, no new province has been created in Pakistan since 1970.

The main reason is lack of political consensus and constitutional agreement.

15. Conclusion

The politics of new provinces in Pakistan reflects deeper issues related to:

- governance
- identity
- resource distribution
- federal balance.

If handled responsibly, creating new provinces could improve governance and strengthen the federation.

However, if driven by ethnic conflict or political opportunism, it may create instability.

Therefore, any decision regarding new provinces must be based on:

- broad political consensus
- constitutional procedures
- economic feasibility
- national unity.

Provincial Local Government Systems of Pakistan

(Comparative Perspective)

1. Introduction: Understanding Local Government

Local Government refers to government institutions operating at the grassroots level. These institutions function at the district, municipal, town, village, and union council levels and are responsible for managing local affairs and providing essential public services.

In democratic political systems, local governments serve as the third tier of governance, alongside:

1. Federal Government
2. Provincial Government
3. Local Government

Importance of Local Government

Local government is essential because it brings governance closer to the people. It allows citizens to participate in decision-making regarding their everyday needs.

Key Functions of Local Governments

Local governments are responsible for:

- Water supply systems
- Sanitation and waste management
- Construction and maintenance of local roads
- Street lighting
- Parks and recreational facilities
- Local schools and libraries
- Basic health facilities
- Local markets and regulation of businesses

Example

If a streetlight is not functioning in a neighborhood:

- The issue is reported to the Union Council or Municipal Committee, not the federal government.

Similarly:

- Garbage collection
- Drainage maintenance
- Local road repairs

are handled by local governments.

Democratic Significance

Local governments strengthen democracy by:

1. Encouraging citizen participation
2. Improving transparency and accountability
3. Allowing citizens to monitor public officials
4. Developing future political leadership

Many national political leaders begin their careers at the local government level.

2. Historical Evolution of Local Government in Pakistan

The structure of local government in Pakistan has evolved through several phases influenced by colonial administration, military regimes, and democratic reforms.

A. Local Government during the British Period

The British colonial administration introduced local government institutions in India during the 19th century.

One of the major reforms was introduced by Lord Ripon in 1882, often referred to as the Father of Local Self-Government in India.

Objectives of British Local Government

The British introduced local governments mainly to:

1. Reduce administrative burden on colonial officials
2. Manage urban services such as sanitation and water supply
3. Incorporate local elites into colonial governance
4. Create limited participation of local populations

However, the system remained highly centralized and bureaucratic.

Role of Deputy Commissioner (DC)

The Deputy Commissioner played a central role in the colonial administrative system.

Responsibilities included:

- Supervising local councils
- Approving budgets
- Overriding local decisions

Thus, local governments existed but lacked real autonomy.

Rural–Urban Divide

The British created separate systems for:

- Urban areas (municipal committees, municipal corporations)
- Rural areas (district boards, union boards)

This division influenced Pakistan's later local government structures.

B. Local Government after Independence (1947–1958)

After independence in 1947, Pakistan inherited the colonial administrative system.

However, the new state faced several challenges:

- Weak political institutions
- Centralized bureaucracy

- Limited democratic experience

Weaknesses of Early Local Governments

Local governments during this period remained weak due to:

1. Provincial government control
2. Limited financial autonomy
3. Strong bureaucratic supervision

Local councils could not:

- approve budgets independently
- implement development projects without provincial approval.

3. Major Local Government Systems in Pakistan

Pakistan's local government systems were largely introduced during military regimes, which attempted to legitimize their rule through grassroots political structures.

Three major systems emerged:

1. Basic Democracies System (1959)
2. Local Government Ordinance (1979)
3. Local Government Ordinance (2001)

1. Basic Democracies System 1959 (Ayub Khan)

General Ayub Khan introduced the Basic Democracies Order in 1959.

This system aimed to establish a controlled form of democracy under military rule.

Structure of Basic Democracies

The system had four administrative tiers:

1. Union Councils (village level)
2. Tehsil Councils
3. District Councils
4. Divisional Councils

At the lowest level, Union Councils represented rural communities.

Electoral College Function

Approximately 80,000 Basic Democrats were elected across the country.

These representatives served as:

- Local council members
- Electoral college for presidential elections

Thus, the President was indirectly elected by Basic Democrats.

Role of Bureaucracy

Despite elected councils, bureaucracy remained dominant.

Deputy Commissioners had authority to:

- suspend council resolutions
- approve or reject development plans
- supervise financial decisions.

Criticism of Basic Democracies System

The system faced strong criticism because:

- It centralized power in the presidency.
- Local representatives had limited authority.
- It was used to legitimize authoritarian rule.

Nevertheless, it helped introduce local political participation in rural areas.

2. Local Government Ordinance 1979 (Zia-ul-Haq)

General Zia-ul-Haq introduced another local government system in 1979.

Unlike Ayub's system, Zia's reforms emphasized local administrative governance rather than electoral legitimacy.

Structure of Local Governments

The system had separate structures for rural and urban areas.

Rural Structure

1. Union Council
2. Tehsil Council
3. District Council

Urban Structure

Urban areas had different municipal bodies:

- Town Committees
- Municipal Committees
- Municipal Corporations
- Metropolitan Corporations

Key Features

1. Indirect elections for chairmen

2. Limited bureaucratic interference compared to Ayub's system
3. Local taxation powers

Local councils could collect:

- property taxes
- toll taxes
- service fees.

Limitations

Despite improvements, provincial governments retained authority to:

- suspend local governments
- dissolve councils
- control development budgets.

3 ☐ Local Government Ordinance 2001 (Musharraf)

General Pervez Musharraf introduced the Devolution of Power Plan in 2001, which was the most ambitious local government reform in Pakistan.

Key Objective

The reform aimed to transfer political, administrative, and financial authority from provinces to districts.

This process was called devolution.

Administrative Structure

Three-tier structure:

1. Union Council
2. Tehsil/Town Council
3. District Council

The system abolished the traditional urban-rural administrative divide.

District Government

District governments became the most important administrative unit.

Each district had:

- District Nazim (elected political head)
- District Coordination Officer (senior bureaucrat)

The DCO reported to the Nazim.

Devolution of Departments

Several provincial departments were transferred to district governments, including:

- health
- education
- agriculture
- social welfare.

However, some sectors remained under provincial control, such as:

- police
- higher education
- irrigation
- electricity.

Citizen Participation Mechanisms

The 2001 system introduced several mechanisms to increase public participation.

Citizen Community Boards (CCBs)

Local communities could propose development projects.

Government would fund 80% of project cost, while citizens contributed 20%.

Zila Mohtasib

District-level ombudsman responsible for addressing complaints against government officials.

Muslihat Committees

Local dispute resolution bodies designed to reduce burden on courts.

Weaknesses of the 2001 System

Despite innovative features, the system faced challenges:

- non-party elections weakened political accountability
- provincial governments opposed devolution
- lack of sustainable financial autonomy.

After 2001, the system was largely dismantled.

4. The 18th Constitutional Amendment (2010)

The 18th Amendment significantly changed Pakistan's federal structure.

It transferred many powers from the federal government to provinces.

Article 140A

Article 140A requires each province to:

- establish a local government system
- devolve political, administrative, and financial authority.

It also requires local government elections to be conducted by the Election Commission of Pakistan.

Significance

For the first time, local governments received constitutional protection.

However, provinces retained flexibility in designing their systems.

5. Provincial Local Government Acts (2013)

Following the 18th Amendment, each province enacted its own local government law in 2013.

This resulted in different structures across provinces.

6. Provincial Structural Comparison

Punjab

Punjab restored the urban-rural administrative divide.

Rural Structure

- Union Council
- District Council

Urban Structure

- Municipal Committee
- Municipal Corporation
- Metropolitan Corporation

Special Administrative Authorities

Punjab created specialized authorities such as:

- District Education Authorities
- District Health Authorities

These bodies remained under provincial government control, reducing local government autonomy.

Sindh

Sindh's system also maintained separate urban and rural structures.

In large cities like Karachi:

- Union Committees replaced Union Councils.

The Mayor has supervisory authority, but provincial government retains strong administrative control.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KPK)

KPK introduced one of the most decentralized systems.

Structure:

- District Council
- Tehsil Council
- Village Council
- Neighborhood Council

Village councils directly engage with local communities.

The province guaranteed 30% of development budget for local governments.

Balochistan

Balochistan's system resembles earlier local government structures.

However:

- provincial government retains strong administrative supervision
- divisional coordination committees monitor local development.

7. Electoral Representation

Population coverage varies widely.

Province	Population per Local Unit
KPK	2,000–10,000
Balochistan	1,000–1,500
Punjab	10,000–20,000
Sindh	40,000–50,000

This affects citizen representation and participation.

8. Administrative Authority

KPK provides the highest level of local autonomy.

Punjab and Sindh maintain stronger bureaucratic control.

Balochistan relies heavily on provincial supervision.

9. Fiscal Devolution

Local governments generate revenue through:

- property tax

- license fees
- fines
- tolls
- provincial transfers.

However, local governments in Pakistan depend heavily on provincial grants, limiting financial autonomy.

10. Supervision and Accountability

Provincial governments supervise local governments through:

- Local Government Commissions
- Audit mechanisms
- Administrative inspections.

Provincial authorities may suspend or dissolve councils if necessary.

11. Major Structural Problems

Several challenges persist:

1. Provincial dominance over local governments
2. Weak financial autonomy
3. Limited taxation authority
4. Bureaucratic control over administration
5. Weak metropolitan governance.

Large cities like Karachi and Lahore require stronger metropolitan systems.

12. Human Development Impact

Evidence suggests that stronger local governments improve development outcomes.

During 2001–2007, Pakistan’s Human Development Index improved significantly due to:

- improved service delivery
- better monitoring of development programs.

13. Key Analytical Observations

Important conclusions include:

- party-based elections strengthen political accountability
- suspension powers weaken local autonomy
- financial independence is essential for effective governance
- citizen participation mechanisms must be strengthened.

14. Conclusion

Local governments play a crucial role in strengthening democracy and improving governance in Pakistan.

Although constitutional reforms have strengthened local governance frameworks, significant challenges remain.

To make local governments effective, Pakistan must ensure:

- real administrative authority
- fiscal independence
- citizen participation
- reduced bureaucratic interference.

Strengthening local governments can significantly improve service delivery, democratic participation, and development outcomes.

For the sake of just information

7. Electoral Representation

Electoral representation in local governments refers to how citizens elect their representatives at the grassroots level and how many people are represented by each elected official. It determines how effectively people's voices are included in local decision-making.

Local government elections allow citizens to choose representatives such as:

- Union Council members
- Chairpersons or Nazims
- Mayors
- District Council members
- Village and Neighborhood Council representatives

These representatives are responsible for solving local issues, managing development projects, and representing community interests.

1. Importance of Electoral Representation

Electoral representation is important because it ensures that local governments remain democratic and accountable to the people.

When citizens elect representatives directly:

- Government becomes more responsive to local needs
- Communities have a stronger voice in development planning
- Citizens can hold officials accountable through elections

For example:

If residents are unhappy with poor sanitation or damaged roads, they can vote against the local representative in the next election.

2. Population Representation Differences Across Provinces

The population size represented by each local government unit differs significantly among provinces. This affects the level of representation and accessibility between citizens and their elected officials.

Province	Average Population Represented
Khyber Pakhtunkhwa	2,000 – 10,000
Balochistan	1,000 – 1,500
Punjab	10,000 – 20,000
Sindh	40,000 – 50,000

3. Impact of Population Size on Representation

The size of the population represented by each local government unit directly influences the quality of governance and citizen participation.

Smaller Population Units (KPK and Balochistan)

When fewer people are represented:

- Representatives are closer to the community
- Citizens can easily contact their representatives
- Local problems are identified and solved more quickly

Example:

In a village council of 2,000 people, the elected representative personally knows many residents and can easily respond to issues like:

- water shortages
- road repairs
- school maintenance.

Larger Population Units (Punjab and Sindh)

When representatives serve larger populations:

- Communication between citizens and representatives becomes more difficult
- Local issues may receive less attention
- Representatives may struggle to manage multiple communities simultaneously

Example:

In some urban union committees in Sindh, a single representative may represent tens of thousands of residents, making it harder to address every local concern.

4. Electoral Systems Used in Local Governments

Local governments in Pakistan generally use direct elections, where citizens vote directly for their representatives.

Common electoral positions include:

- Chairman or Nazim
- Vice Chairman
- Council Members
- Mayor (in metropolitan cities)

However, the method of election varies between provinces.

Party-Based Elections

In some provinces, elections are held on party lines, meaning candidates represent political parties.

Advantages:

- Strengthens political accountability
- Links local government to national political parties
- Encourages organized political participation

Example:

A candidate representing a political party may campaign on promises such as:

- improved waste management
- better road infrastructure.

Non-Party Elections

Some local government elections have been conducted without party affiliation.

Advantages:

- Focus on local issues rather than national politics
- Encourages community-based leadership

Disadvantages:

- Weakens political accountability
- Candidates may lack strong organizational support.

5. Reserved Seats for Representation

To promote inclusiveness, local governments include reserved seats for certain groups.

These include:

- Women
- Youth
- Workers and peasants
- Religious minorities

This system ensures that marginalized groups are represented in decision-making processes.

Example:

Women council members may advocate for:

- girls' education
- maternal healthcare
- protection against domestic violence.

6. Urban vs Rural Representation

Representation also varies between urban and rural areas.

Rural Areas

Rural areas usually have:

- Union Councils
- Village Councils

These units represent smaller populations and focus on issues like:

- irrigation
- agriculture
- rural infrastructure.

Urban Areas

Urban areas have larger administrative bodies such as:

- Municipal Committees
- Municipal Corporations
- Metropolitan Corporations

Urban representatives deal with complex problems including:

- traffic congestion
- urban planning
- waste management
- public transport.

7. Challenges in Electoral Representation

Despite democratic elections, several challenges affect effective representation.

1. Population Imbalance

Some areas have **too many people per representative**, reducing accessibility.

2. Political Interference

Provincial governments sometimes influence local politics, weakening local independence

3. Delayed Elections

Local government elections are occasionally delayed or suspended, which reduces democratic participation.

4. Limited Authority

Even though representatives are elected, they often have limited decision-making powers due to provincial control.

8. Importance for Democratic Development

Strong electoral representation at the local level contributes to:

- democratic stability
- political participation
- leadership development.

Many national leaders begin their careers in local government institutions, gaining experience in governance and public service.